

MEETING NOTES

Pedestrian Advisory Committee
Wednesday, September 12, 2018
Brookline Town Hall, Room 408
Minutes submitted by Tracy Bare

Members present: Frank Caro, Jane Ross, Tracy Bare, Allison Pincus-Jacobs, Bob Sloane **Member absent:** David Trevvett

1. Topics not on the agenda

Frank says warrant article 23 for the November Town Meeting proposes to on bringing back the bridle path on Beacon St. The petitioner is Jules Milner-Brage. We will put this on our agenda for the next meeting. The warrant is on the town website for Town Meeting. There will be an Advisory Committee Capital Subcommittee on the warrant article on September 27 at 5:30 PM.

2. Review of minutes of June meeting

Reviewed and approved.

3. Coolidge Corner neighborhood walk July meeting: review of notes taken by Jane Ross and open discussion

The suggestion of yellow paint on Webster St. traffic-calming island would be easy to implement.

Jane will speak to the United Parish about the seating on their bench and any seating in the shade.

Frank suggested that the Town study speeds of cars turning from Beacon onto Webster and proceeding down Webster. Allison wonders about sight lines on Beacon turning to Webster due to large bushes. We should suggest that Transportation Board consider a study here. Bob suggests that we do a preliminary

review of speeds of cars there, he has equipment for that. Bob also wonders if the bump-outs near the hotel are serving their purpose. We should have some data to support our concerns. Bob will come up with a proposal for us and we will collect data.

Parklet at intersections of Stearns, Harvard and Sewall. There are thorny suckers from the honey locust tree and also “volcano” shaped awkward rock seating but no bench. Frank says that that area is supervised by Parks and Open Space. We should suggest that the Parks and Open Space Division look at it for placement of benches and improved maintenance. Frank will follow up with Erin Gallentine, the division director.

Sewall doesn't really give people access to Beacon/Post Office area. The street is pedestrian unfriendly on the North/West side (behind the post office, by the synagogue, and next to the Partner's Urgent Care center) due to the number of curb cuts. The other side is somewhat better but has limited crosswalks. Some pedestrians use Trader Joe's as a cut through but the parking lot is hazardous for pedestrians. The proposed development at Neena's will exacerbate this unless it reinstates the old pass-through to Beacon which has been closed off for several years.

A number of observations could be reported through BrookOnline. Others are complicated and deserve study. We have three levels of observations: easy to fix (like overgrown hedge on Green), medium (like curb cuts between Coolidge Corner Theatre and Center Street), and in need of professional study (like Longwood/Sewall/Charles). Bob points out that perhaps merchants have some thoughts on some of these issues. Frank will communicate with the Coolidge Corner Merchant's Association.

Jane: Shall we cull the list from July minutes into the three categories? Frank agrees that we should do that and he will write up a paragraph on the issue of Longwood/Sewall/Charles pedestrian flow.

The notes were approved as Minutes. The action items discussed above will be acted on at the October meeting.

4. Regulation of electric scooters and bicycles on sidewalks

Frank discussed that over the summer motorized scooters were being advertised and they are on the sidewalk going 15+ miles per hour. They can go up to 23 mph. Transportation Board will need to look into amendment of traffic regulations as these are not currently covered. Frank spoke to the rental company, which expects that they will be in the street or bike lane. A bylaw that restricts use of sidewalks is very outdated and refers to horses and carriages. Todd previously suggested to Frank that language could be added to traffic regulations to prohibit motorized scooters and electric bicycles on sidewalks. (Changes in bylaws require action by Town Meeting; the Transportation Board can amend traffic regulations. Frank wonders how well these regulations would be enforced. For now, simplest change is to suggest a change in the regulations to the Transportation Board. Bob points out that Cambridge and Boston are also looking at this right now. Bob will look into which people in the area are currently working on this and Frank will contact them.

5. Possible Brookline participation in Vision Zero initiative

Bob explains that Vision Zero is looking to reduce crashes involving pedestrians. Data would need to be collected and analyzed to see if we could reduce these in Brookline. Boston is participating in Vision Zero and is hiring staff. Boston neighborhoods are looking at this as well. Jane says Brookline has a map of pedestrian crashes as part

of Complete Streets. Frank spoke to Chris Dempsey about this and Chris was concerned about staffing. Town only has two professionals in the Transportation Department. Perhaps we could just do some of what Vision Zero suggests regarding pedestrians, without the formal commitment. Brookline efforts are likely to depend largely on volunteer effort. Frank noted it is mostly bigger cities that are participating in Vision Zero. Somerville is one smaller city that is participating. Somerville is at the early stages in its effort. Bob offered to look into Somerville's actions and what we can do with our limited capacity.

6. Continued consideration of crosswalks on Beacon Street, Harvard Street, and Washington Street that may merit Pedestrian Warning Signals

We had discussed observations made by Jane and David at night. Franks thinks we should go back in the daytime when traffic is heavier, as it is not just a nighttime issue. We also need to look at Harvard Street. There are many more crosswalks on Harvard North of Coolidge Corner, than between Coolidge Corner and Brookline Village. We do not know the reasoning behind this.

7. Complete Streets prioritization plan list of projects

Todd Kirrane explained the application to Mass DOT for Complete Streets funding. There are a number of pedestrian improvements on the application. The first set of projects (of the total five year cycle) was a mix. The Town has a Wikimap of the 700 comments/suggestions people had for improvements and will use it as a resource going forward. Over 40% of these suggestions were pedestrian-related. The Wikimap is now closed after having been up for two months. Decisions on funding are expected from the State in October. The application plan was approved without discussion by Transportation Board, so decision-making was in the hands of staff and consultants for the most part,

based on what was easier to accomplish given current projects. The maximum amount is \$400,000.

8. Committee housekeeping concerns

a. Expired terms of Jane Ross and Frank Caro

_____Jane and Frank are on agenda of Transportation Board to be reappointed for 3 years as first term was only one year.

b. Proposal for postponement of election of chair

We will vote on this in October.

c. Website

Frank noted that there was confusion when the Town website was improved this summer and some information was lost. Todd Kirrane explained that information from early May to late June was lost when company captured and then reposted new website. Frank asked if there was capacity of the Town website for additional information/documents. Todd says that is possible. We will make a recommendation on the manner in which documents like our Longwood Avenue study can be posted on the website.

9. New business

America Walks has a webinar monthly. Jane has been participating. This month's was about criminalization of walking. In Florida, you can lose your driver's license for certain pedestrian violations. They talked about safety on major roads.

Meeting adjourned at 8:50 p.m.